

CIA director's Moscow visit likely a warning

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CIA Director John Ratcliffe's rare trip to Moscow likely served a dual purpose: warning Russia against attacking NATO's Baltic members while quietly o||||||||||||||

Quick take

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Ratcliffe's Moscow trip likely a warning—and a backchannel

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What Happened

CIA Director John Ratcliffe made a rare, unannounced trip to Moscow on 25 August for talks with Russian intelligence officials.

Our Take

Trips like this are unusual for CIA directors, occurring only twice in the past decade. Then-director William Burns traveled to Moscow in November 2021 to warn President Vladimir Putin against invading Ukraine. John Brennan traveled to Moscow in early March 2016 when he was director to provide a warning on Syria and open a channel to begin discussing the potential political transition of Syria's then-president Bashar al Assad.

Ratcliffe likely warned Russia against attacking NATO and opened a backchannel on Ukraine. People briefed on the trip said the purpose was to warn Moscow not to attack NATO countries, particularly Estonia, Latvia, and Lithuania. Burns met Russia's foreign intelligence chief, Sergei Naryshkin, in Ankara in November 2022 to issue a warning, but he also opened a quiet channel on Ukraine. The Burns-Naryshkin meeting illustrates how Washington uses these interactions to set expectations while maintaining an opening for communication in case of further escalation.

An open channel does not imply that negotiations are about to move. US-mediated talks remain largely stalled, and Washington has stressed these engagements are about managing risks rather than settling the war. Russia has the means and incentive to escalate rather than engage. Fiscal pressures, declining public support, and a lack of battlefield progress are pushing the Kremlin away from diplomacy. We expect more severe strikes on Ukrainian infrastructure and a troop buildup ahead of a possible push later this year. We don't foresee meaningful diplomatic movement until after Russia tests Ukraine's resilience.

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